ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Syntactic ambiguity and control

Diagnose attachment, scope and control ambiguities and revise clause architecture so only the intended interpretation remains available. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use syntactic ambiguity and control to prevent advanced compression from creating competing readings about agency, modification or logical scope while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Diagnose attachment, scope and control ambiguities and revise clause architecture so only the intended interpretation remains available.

MODEL

After reviewing the file, the analyst—not the conclusion—appeared uncertain.

identify competing parses -> expose intended relation -> rewrite

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main syntactic ambiguity and control patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses prevent advanced compression from creating competing readings about agency, modification or logical scope.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in legal, technical, academic and high-stakes professional writing.

Build meaning before form

Diagnose attachment, scope and control ambiguities and revise clause architecture so only the intended interpretation remains available.

What syntactic ambiguity and control communicates

Diagnose attachment, scope and control ambiguities and revise clause architecture so only the intended interpretation remains available.

The central purpose is to prevent advanced compression from creating competing readings about agency, modification or logical scope. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix.	the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method
The policy does not require all applicants to attend.	negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself
After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain.	the analyst clearly understood as reviewer

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: identify competing parses -> expose intended relation -> rewrite. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “After reviewing the file, the analyst—not the conclusion—appeared uncertain.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Attachment repair	move modifier beside its host	The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix.
Scope repair	repeat or reposition operator	The policy does not require all applicants to attend.
Control repair	name the understood subject	After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method	Attachment repair
negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself	Scope repair
the analyst clearly understood as reviewer	Control repair

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in legal, technical, academic and high-stakes professional writing. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01

identify competing parses -> expose intended relation -> rewrite

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: prevent advanced compression from creating competing readings about agency, modification or logical scope.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits legal, technical, academic and high-stakes professional writing.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Attachment repair	move modifier beside its host	The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix.
Scope repair	repeat or reposition operator	The policy does not require all applicants to attend.
Control repair	name the understood subject	After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix.	the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method
The policy does not require all applicants to attend.	negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself
After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain.	the analyst clearly understood as reviewer

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not leave a final modifier equally able to attach to two constituents.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Test whether not all and all not express the same intended claim.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not attach a non-finite clause to a main subject that cannot perform its action.

01 · PRACTICE STAGE

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method?

OPTIONS The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix. · The policy does not require all applicants to attend. · After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself?

OPTIONS The policy does not require all applicants to attend. · After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain. · The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: the analyst clearly understood as reviewer?

OPTIONS After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain. · The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix. · The policy does not require all applicants to attend.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method · negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself · the analyst clearly understood as reviewer

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The policy does not require all applicants to attend.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself · the analyst clearly understood as reviewer · the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS the analyst clearly understood as reviewer · the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method · negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Attachment repair / Scope repair / Control repair · Gap 2: the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method / negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself / the analyst clearly understood as reviewer

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“The policy does not require all applicants to attend.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Scope repair / Control repair / Attachment repair · Gap 2: negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself / the analyst clearly understood as reviewer / the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Control repair / Attachment repair / Scope repair · Gap 2: the analyst clearly understood as reviewer / the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method / negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method: _____. Choose the model that expresses negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself: _____. Choose the model that expresses the analyst clearly understood as reviewer: _____. Choose the model built with move modifier beside its host: _____. Choose the model built with repeat or reposition operator: _____. Choose the model built with name the understood subject: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain. · The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix. · The policy does not require all applicants to attend.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The analyst reviewed the _____. The policy _____ to attend. After reviewing the file, _____. State the full structural pattern for Attachment repair: _____. State the full structural pattern for Scope repair: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The analyst used the report that contained the revised appendix.” using the Attachment repair pattern to express the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “Not every applicant is required to attend.” using the Scope repair pattern to express negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The analyst reviewed the file and appeared uncertain.” using the Control repair pattern to express the analyst clearly understood as reviewer.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The analyst used the report that contained the revised appendix.” using the Attachment repair pattern to express the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Attachment repair to express the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Scope repair to express negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Control repair to express the analyst clearly understood as reviewer, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix.

Attachment repair is the best match because the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method.

A2

The policy does not require all applicants to attend.

Scope repair is the best match because negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself.

A3

After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain.

Control repair is the best match because the analyst clearly understood as reviewer.

A4

the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method

The Attachment repair pattern communicates the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method.

A5

negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself

The Scope repair pattern communicates negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself.

A6

the analyst clearly understood as reviewer

The Control repair pattern communicates the analyst clearly understood as reviewer.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Attachment repair / the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method

The structure belongs to the Attachment repair pattern. Its communicative purpose is the appendix clearly attached to the report rather than the reviewing method.

B2

Scope repair / negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself

The structure belongs to the Scope repair pattern. Its communicative purpose is negation scoped over universal obligation rather than over attendance itself.

B3

Control repair / the analyst clearly understood as reviewer

The structure belongs to the Control repair pattern. Its communicative purpose is the analyst clearly understood as reviewer.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix.

Attachment repair: move modifier beside its host.

C2

The policy does not require all applicants to attend.

Scope repair: repeat or reposition operator.

C3

After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain.

Control repair: name the understood subject.

C4

The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix.

Attachment repair: move modifier beside its host.

C5

The policy does not require all applicants to attend.

Scope repair: repeat or reposition operator.

C6

After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain.

Control repair: name the understood subject.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

report with the revised appendix

Attachment repair requires “report with the revised appendix” in this model. move modifier beside its host.

D2

does not require all applicants

Scope repair requires “does not require all applicants” in this model. repeat or reposition operator.

D3

the analyst appeared uncertain

Control repair requires “the analyst appeared uncertain” in this model. name the understood subject.

D4

move modifier beside its host

Attachment repair is built as move modifier beside its host.

D5

repeat or reposition operator

Scope repair is built as repeat or reposition operator.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix.

move modifier beside its host. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended attachment repair effect.

E2

The policy does not require all applicants to attend.

repeat or reposition operator. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended scope repair effect.

E3

After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain.

name the understood subject. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended control repair effect.

E4

The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix.

move modifier beside its host. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended attachment repair effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The analyst reviewed the report with the revised appendix. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses move modifier beside its host accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The policy does not require all applicants to attend. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses repeat or reposition operator accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

After reviewing the file, the analyst appeared uncertain. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses name the understood subject accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____